insight. I maintain that the keys to understanding Indian philosophy are to be found in the dialectic between the anti-essentialist Buddhist outlook that reality is to be understood fundamentally as an impersonal process of events from which the notion of individual identities is an abstraction, and the Brahminical Hindu view that it is the interactions between persisting stable identities or substances that generate processes. Further, there is the dialectic between the view that the values encoded in the orthodox hierarchical ideology of social and religious duty (*dharma*) are absolutes and the subversive belief that they are only human constructs. Again, there is the dialectic between the view that the world as represented in the categories of common sense is what it seems (the lotus growing out of the mud) and the conviction that the differences and oppositions that we experience are misconceptions resolvable into a higher unifying synthesis.

About thirty years ago my teacher Julius Lipner expressed the modest aspiration that one of our duties as students of Indian thought was that of helping to dissolve the misconceptions about those traditions current in the West. I hope that this book is a step in the right direction.